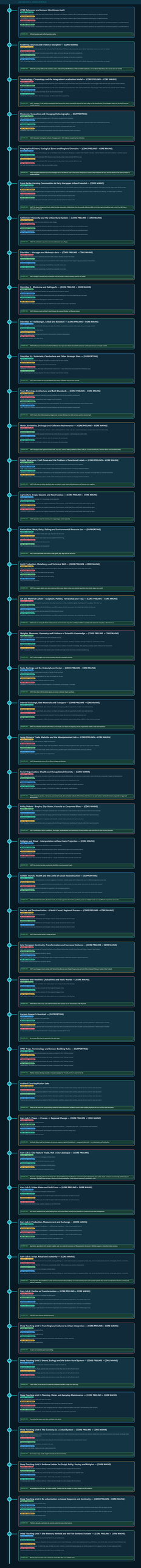

01

UPSC Relevance and Answer-Worthiness Audit

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The Harappan Civilization is high-value direct Prelims history: chronology, sites, features, material culture, trade and statement matching recur in objective formats.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The Harappan Civilization is high-value direct Prelims history: chronology, sites, features, material culture, trade and statement matching recur in objective formats.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It is not separately named in the printed GS-I Mains syllabus, but can directly support Mains culture, architecture and urbanism questions; the routed 2025 GS-I architecture question is a verified demand.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It is not separately named in the printed GS-I Mains syllabus, but can directly support Mains culture, architecture and urbanism questions; the routed 2025 GS-I architecture question is a verified demand.

ANSWER LINE: **Official boundary and verified-question reality.**

02

Roadmap, Sources and Evidence Discipline — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: This package follows the mandatory order: authored Topic 06 Markdown, OCR-searchable local books, and no Qdrant dependency; live sources were not needed.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

RECALL: The script is undeciphered; conclusions about polity, religion and social ideology are therefore probabilistic.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: The script is undeciphered; conclusions about polity, religion and social ideology are therefore probabilistic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: This package follows the mandatory order: authored Topic 06 Markdown, OCR-searchable local books, and no Qdrant dependency; live sources were not needed.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: This package follows the mandatory order: authored Topic 06 Markdown, OCR-searchable local books, and no Qdrant dependency; live sources were not needed.**

03

Terminology, Chronology and the Integration-Localisation Model — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: "Harappan" is the safest archaeological label because the culture extended far beyond the Indus valley and the identification of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati remains debated.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: "Harappan" is the safest archaeological label because the culture extended far beyond the Indus valley and the identification of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati remains debated.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

2600-1900 BCE for the urban phase, but dates vary by site and remain revisable.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: The tripartite scheme describes processes, not three sealed ethnic populations.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: "Harappan" is the safest archaeological label because the culture extended far beyond the Indus valley and the identification of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati remains debated.**

04

Discovery, Excavation and Changing Historiography — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Alexander Cunningham noticed a Harappan seal in 1853 without recognizing the civilization.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

MAINS ANGLE: Historiography is a movement from diffusion, monarchy and invasion toward indigenous development, regional variation and multidisciplinary process.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Banerji worked at Mohenjo-daro; John Marshall announced the civilization and supervised major work.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: New methods have not removed interpretation; they have made the evidentiary chain more explicit.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Alexander Cunningham noticed a Harappan seal in 1853 without recognizing the civilization.**

05

Geographical Extent, Ecological Zones and Regional Domains — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Harappan settlements occur from Sutkagen-dor on the Makran coast in the west to Alamgirpur in western Uttar Pradesh in the east, and from Manda in the north to Malvan in southern Gujarat.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Published culture-zone area estimates differ because survey intensity, phase criteria and site definitions vary.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: Published culture-zone area estimates differ because survey intensity, phase criteria and site definitions vary.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Use "vast, multi-ecological zone" rather than one immutable number.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Harappan settlements occur from Sutkagen-dor on the Makran coast in the west to Alamgirpur in western Uttar Pradesh in the east, and from Manda in the north to Malvan in southern Gujarat.**

06

From Earlier Farming Communities to Early Harappan Urban Potential — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: The deeper background lies in settled farming communities of Baluchistan from the seventh millennium BCE and in later regional traditions such as Amri, Kot Diji, Hakra, Sothi-Siswal and Ravi.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Urbanisation emerged through convergence among regional traditions, craft intensification, exchange, agricultural surplus, leadership and ideology; no single trigger is sufficient.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Some mature sites lack known early levels, and some early sites did not become mature cities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

RECALL: Some mature sites lack known early levels, and some early sites did not become mature cities.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: The deeper background lies in settled farming communities of Baluchistan from the seventh millennium BCE and in later regional traditions such as Amri, Kot Diji, Hakra, Sothi-Siswal and Ravi.**

07

Settlement Hierarchy and the Urban-Rural System — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: The civilization was urban, but most settlements were villages.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Standardisation across this hierarchy required coordination, but it does not by itself prove one centralized empire.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Standardisation across this hierarchy required coordination, but it does not by itself prove one centralized empire.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: Standardisation across this hierarchy required coordination, but it does not by itself prove one centralized empire.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: The civilization was urban, but most settlements were villages.**

08

Site Atlas I - Harappa and Mohenjo-daro — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Harappa's mounds cover an extensive area and include a mature cemetery south of the citadel.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Mound F contained craft-related structures and circular platforms where husked barley and straw support a grain-processing interpretation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Its secure significance is collective engineering; ritual bathing is plausible, not proven.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Its secure significance is collective engineering; ritual bathing is plausible, not proven.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Harappa's mounds cover an extensive area and include a mature cemetery south of the citadel.**

09

Site Atlas II - Dholavira and Rakhigarhi — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Dholavira stood on Khadir island between the seasonal Manhar and Mansar streams.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Dams diverted water into reservoirs; stone masonry and a multi-part plan distinguish it from the simple two-part city model.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: The Dholavira signboard used large gypsum symbols once inlaid in wood.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It demonstrates civic display of writing but does not reveal the city's name until the script is deciphered.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Dholavira stood on Khadir island between the seasonal Manhar and Mansar streams.**

10

Site Atlas III - Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Kalibangan's lower town lacked the Mohenjo-daro type street drains; household wastewater could empty into jars or troughs outside.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

This is regional variation, not urban failure.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: Lothal's basin had a sluice and spill channel in the excavator's dockyard interpretation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

This is regional variation, not urban failure.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Kalibangan's lower town lacked the Mohenjo-daro type street drains; household wastewater could empty into jars or troughs outside.**

11

Site Atlas IV - Surkotada, Chanhudaro and Other Strategic Sites — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Horse remains are rare and disputed; the mature civilization was not horse-centred.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The humped bull and cattle economy are much more characteristic.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Chanhudaro proves that major craft production could occur in a town without the monumental form of Mohenjo-daro.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: Horse remains are rare and disputed; the mature civilization was not horse-centred.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Horse remains are rare and disputed; the mature civilization was not horse-centred.**

12

Town Planning, Architecture and Built Standards — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Streets often followed planned alignments, but even Mohenjo-daro did not have a perfect universal grid.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Houses usually opened into side lanes and were arranged around courtyards.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Modularity implies shared training, norms and coordination, but not necessarily direct bureaucratic control of every mason.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: Streets often followed planned alignments, but even Mohenjo-daro did not have a perfect universal grid.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Streets often followed planned alignments, but even Mohenjo-daro did not have a perfect universal grid.**

13

Water, Sanitation, Drainage and Collective Maintenance — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Harappan water systems included wells, reservoirs, cisterns, bathing platforms, toilets, soak-pits, covered street drains, rainwater drains and controlled outlets.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Infrastructure required repeated maintenance by workers whose social position is archaeologically under-visible.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Sewage channels and rainwater collection were not necessarily the same system.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

RECALL: Sewage channels and rainwater collection were not necessarily the same system.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Harappan water systems included wells, reservoirs, cisterns, bathing platforms, toilets, soak-pits, covered street drains, rainwater drains and controlled outlets.**

14

Public Structures, Craft Zones and the Problem of Functional Labels — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Craft areas are better identified when raw material, waste, tools, unfinished pieces and furnaces occur together.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

TRAP: A large building is automatically a palace, temple or state warehouse. || Function requires converging contextual evidence.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Public buildings reveal labour mobilisation, but the responsible institution could have been rulers, councils, merchants, ritual specialists or combined authorities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

TRAP: A large building is automatically a palace, temple or state warehouse. || Function requires converging contextual evidence.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Craft areas are better identified when raw material, waste, tools, unfinished pieces and furnaces occur together.**

15

Agriculture, Crops, Seasons and Food Surplus — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Agriculture was the mainstay, but crop packages varied regionally.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Surplus did not arise from one irrigation bureaucracy; flood recession, rainfall, wells, bunds and limited canals varied by region.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Surplus did not arise from one irrigation bureaucracy; flood recession, rainfall, wells, bunds and limited canals varied by region.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: Surplus did not arise from one irrigation bureaucracy; flood recession, rainfall, wells, bunds and limited canals varied by region.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Agriculture was the mainstay, but crop packages varied regionally.**

16

Pastoralism, Meat, Dairy, Fishing and Environmental Resource Use — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Cattle and buffalo were central; sheep, goats, pigs, dogs and cats also occur.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Hunting, fishing, shellfish collection and coastal resources supplemented farming.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: The horse is rare, debated and not characteristic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: The horse is rare, debated and not characteristic.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Cattle and buffalo were central; sheep, goats, pigs, dogs and cats also occur.**

17

Craft Production, Metallurgy and Technical Skill — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Pure copper objects were more numerous than bronze objects; alloys were selected especially where harder edges were useful.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: The bronze "Dancing Girl" was made by lost-wax casting.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: The bronze "Dancing Girl" was made by lost-wax casting.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

This is not technological ignorance.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Pure copper objects were more numerous than bronze objects; alloys were selected especially where harder edges were useful.**

18

Art and Material Culture - Sculpture, Pottery, Terracottas and Toys — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Seals are among the finest artistic products, but terracottas range from carefully modelled to quickly made objects for everyday or short-term use.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Differences in materials, skill and distribution may reflect audience, function and access, not a simple high-art/low-art hierarchy.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: The 2025 Prelims question asks the material of the Dancing Girl: bronze.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: Differences in materials, skill and distribution may reflect audience, function and access, not a simple high-art/low-art hierarchy.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Seals are among the finest artistic products, but terracottas range from carefully modelled to quickly made objects for everyday or short-term use.**

19

Weights, Measures, Geometry and Evidence of Scientific Knowledge — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Cubical weights occur across excavated sites with remarkable accuracy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Standardization could arise through state regulation, merchant coordination, hereditary specialists, exchange networks or combinations of these.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: The 2026 Prelims PYQ correctly treats weights and graduated scales as evidence of scientific knowledge, while rejecting a property-system inference from house form.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

TRAP: "Multiple of 16" alone describes the whole weight system. || Smaller and larger series show binary and decimal patterning.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Cubical weights occur across excavated sites with remarkable accuracy.**

20

Seals, Sealings and the Undeciphered Script — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: More than 6,000 inscribed objects are known in Upinder Singh's synthesis.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Most inscriptions are short, averaging about five signs; the longest has 26 signs.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: Dholavira's large signboard indicates public/civic writing.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: A common script supports cultural integration, not necessarily one language or one state.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: More than 6,000 inscribed objects are known in Upinder Singh's synthesis.**

21

Internal Exchange, Raw Materials and Transport — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Two-wheeled carts with solid wheels, pack animals, river boats and seagoing craft are supported by models, tracks and depictions.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Two-wheeled carts with solid wheels, pack animals, river boats and seagoing craft are supported by models, tracks and depictions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Internal exchange was more structurally important than the visually attractive but limited Mesopotamian trade.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

TRAP: A non-local bead proves conquest or colony. || It proves movement; the mechanism may be trade, gifting, mobility or down-the-line exchange.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Two-wheeled carts with solid wheels, pack animals, river boats and seagoing craft are supported by models, tracks and depictions.**

22

Long-Distance Trade, Meluhha and the Mesopotamian Link — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Mesopotamian texts refer to Dilmun, Magan and Meluhha.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Dilmun is generally identified with Bahrain; Magan with Oman/Makran; Meluhha probably included the Indus region but its exact scope is debated.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: Possible exports include carnelian beads, textiles, shell and ivory; possible imports include selected metals and luxury materials.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: The evidence supports contact but not dependence.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Mesopotamian texts refer to Dilmun, Magan and Meluhha.**

23

Social Organisation, Wealth and Occupational Diversity — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: House size, location, craft access, ornaments, hoards, diet and burials indicate differentiation, but there are no royal tombs or lavish elite burials comparable to Egypt and Mesopotamia.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

MAINS ANGLE: Argue from converging evidence and finish with the limit imposed by the undeciphered script.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Rank and class differences probably existed, but claims of a Harappan caste system are highly speculative.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

TRAP: Courtyard houses imply common property. || The 2026 PYQ makes this an explicitly invalid inference.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: House size, location, craft access, ornaments, hoards, diet and burials indicate differentiation, but there are no royal tombs or lavish elite burials comparable to Egypt and Mesopotamia.**

24

Polity Debate - Empire, City-States, Councils or Corporate Elites — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Fortifications, labour mobilisation, Shortughai, standardization and maintenance of urban facilities make some form of state structure plausible.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

TRAP: No palace means no state. || Early states can express authority through infrastructure, standards and networks rather than royal monuments.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: The most defensible position is organized authority with uncertain scale, personnel and coercive structure.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

TRAP: No palace means no state. || Early states can express authority through infrastructure, standards and networks rather than royal monuments.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Fortifications, labour mobilisation, Shortughai, standardization and maintenance of urban facilities make some form of state structure plausible.**

25

Religion and Ritual - Interpretation without Back-Projection — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: No structure has been conclusively identified as a monumental temple.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Female figurines are abundant at some sites and rare at others, demonstrating regional or functional variation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: Harappan ritual was plural, household and civic; a single standardized creed cannot be reconstructed.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: Harappan ritual was plural, household and civic; a single standardized creed cannot be reconstructed.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: No structure has been conclusively identified as a monumental temple.**

26

Gender, Burials, Health and the Limits of Social Reconstruction — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Extended inhumation, fractional burial, urn burial suggestive of cremation, symbolic graves and multiple burials occur in different proportions across sites.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Gendered labour may be suggested by food-processing figurines or textile contexts, but exact gender roles cannot be mechanically assigned.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Later research abandoned crude racial typologies for population, diet and disease questions.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: Gendered labour may be suggested by food-processing figurines or textile contexts, but exact gender roles cannot be mechanically assigned.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Extended inhumation, fractional burial, urn burial suggestive of cremation, symbolic graves and multiple burials occur in different proportions across sites.**

27

Decline and Deurbanisation - A Multi-Causal, Regional Process — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Urban decline varied in timing and pace.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: The mature phase was followed by Late Harappan cultures; people and practices did not vanish.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: The mature phase was followed by Late Harappan cultures; people and practices did not vanish.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: The mature phase was followed by Late Harappan cultures; people and practices did not vanish.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Urban decline varied in timing and pace.**

28

Late Harappan Continuity, Transformation and Successor Cultures — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Late Harappan levels overlap with Painted Grey Ware at some Punjab-Haryana sites and with Ochre Coloured Pottery in western Uttar Pradesh.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Overlap shows contact and sequence, not ethnic identity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: Jhukar in Sindh, Cemetery H in Punjab, Rangpur/Rojdi in Gujarat and eastern settlements represent regional trajectories.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Overlap shows contact and sequence, not ethnic identity.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Late Harappan levels overlap with Painted Grey Ware at some Punjab-Haryana sites and with Ochre Coloured Pottery in western Uttar Pradesh.**

29

Relations with Neolithic-Chalcolithic and Vedic Worlds — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Mature cities, script, seals and baked-brick urban systems are not characteristic of the Rig Veda.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Horse-centred Vedic symbolism also contrasts with the marginal Harappan horse.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Horse-centred Vedic symbolism also contrasts with the marginal Harappan horse.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: Mature cities, script, seals and baked-brick urban systems are not characteristic of the Rig Veda.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Mature cities, script, seals and baked-brick urban systems are not characteristic of the Rig Veda.**

30

Current-Research Guardrail — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

No current-affairs item is required for this static topic.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A new excavation, river study, genome result or conservation report may refine a bounded site-level claim only after a primary publication or official report is checked.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A new excavation, river study, genome result or conservation report may refine a bounded site-level claim only after a primary publication or official report is checked.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It must not be used to declare script decipherment, a known polity or one final decline cause.

ANSWER LINE: **No current-affairs item is required for this static topic.**

31

UPSC Traps, Terminology and Answer-Building Rules — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known."

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known."

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known."

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known."

ANSWER LINE: **RECALL: Evidence density: normally 2-3 named examples for 10 marks, 4-6 for 15, and 5-8 for 20.**

32

Audited Core Application Labs

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

These six labs retain the causal teaching needed for Prelims elimination and Mains answers while avoiding duplicate site tours and live-news decoration.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

These six labs retain the causal teaching needed for Prelims elimination and Mains answers while avoiding duplicate site tours and live-news decoration.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

These six labs retain the causal teaching needed for Prelims elimination and Mains answers while avoiding duplicate site tours and live-news decoration.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

These six labs retain the causal teaching needed for Prelims elimination and Mains answers while avoiding duplicate site tours and live-news decoration.

ANSWER LINE: **These six labs retain the causal teaching needed for Prelims elimination and Mains answers while avoiding duplicate site tours and live-news decoration.**

33

Core Lab 1: Phase -> Process -> Regional Change — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

It is not sudden appearance then extinction.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use Early, Mature and Late Harappan as a process sequence: regional foundations -> integrated urban traits -> de-urbanisation and localisation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Mature urbanism is the core factual phase; Late Harappan continuity prevents a one-line collapse story.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It is not sudden appearance then extinction.

ANSWER LINE: **Use Early, Mature and Late Harappan as a process sequence: regional foundations -> integrated urban traits -> de-urbanisation and localisation.**

34

Core Lab 2: Site-Feature Triads, Not a Site Catalogue — [CORE PRELIMS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A feature gains marks only with its site and interpretive caution.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A feature gains marks only with its site and interpretive caution.

ANSWER LINE: **Memorise only high-yield triads: Mohenjo-daro--Great Bath/Dancing Girl; Dholavira--reservoirs/signboard/tripartite plan; Lothal--beads and basin conventionally called dockyard; Kalibangan--ploughed field; Harappa--Ravi/first excavated; Rakhigarhi--major Haryana settlement; Chanhudaro--craft.**

35

Core Lab 3: Urban Water and Built Form — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Dholavira corrects any universal two-part city model through its distinctive tripartite plan and water structures.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Dholavira corrects any universal two-part city model through its distinctive tripartite plan and water structures.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

They do not securely identify kings, a palace, a granary or one central state.

ANSWER LINE: **Grid streets, standard bricks, wells, bathing floors and covered drains securely show planned civic construction and water management.**

36

Core Lab 4: Production, Measurement and Exchange — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The argument should be: evidence of coordination -> craft/exchange implication -> limit on exact political control.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The argument should be: evidence of coordination -> craft/exchange implication -> limit on exact political control.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The argument should be: evidence of coordination -> craft/exchange implication -> limit on exact political control.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

No coinage is known; weights and commodities do not tell us the title of a ruler.

ANSWER LINE: **Agriculture, specialised craft, standard weights, seals, raw-material movement and Mesopotamian references to Meluhha support a networked urban economy.**

37

Core Lab 5: Script, Ritual and Authority — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use 'horned figure', 'female figurines' and 'structure conventionally called...' before advancing a cautious interpretation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.

ANSWER LINE: **Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.**

38

Core Lab 6: Decline as Transformation — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

River/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single cause.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Late Harappan rural communities and diversified agriculture make the safest term de-urbanisation with continuity, not annihilation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

River/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single cause.

ANSWER LINE: **1900 BCE urban features declined unevenly.**

39

Deep Teaching Unit 1: From Regional Cultures to Urban Integration — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A city is not created by one large building.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A city is not created by one large building.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The Early Harappan phase shows several regional communities developing some of these capacities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A city is not created by one large building.

ANSWER LINE: **A city is not created by one large building.**

40

Deep Teaching Unit 2: Extent, Ecology and the Urban-Rural System — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

“Indus Valley” is too narrow if it makes the civilization look like a single river-bank city.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Cities therefore depended on villages, pastoral areas and resource routes; they were not self-sufficient islands.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Cities therefore depended on villages, pastoral areas and resource routes; they were not self-sufficient islands.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Cities therefore depended on villages, pastoral areas and resource routes; they were not self-sufficient islands.

ANSWER LINE: **“Indus Valley” is too narrow if it makes the civilization look like a single river-bank city.**

41

Deep Teaching Unit 3: Planning, Water and Everyday Maintenance — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Town planning means more than a grid seen from above.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Houses had wells, bathing areas and drains; street drains had to be laid out, cleaned and repaired.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The contrast prevents the memorised rule “every Harappan town had a western citadel and eastern lower town” from becoming a false universal.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

They do not reveal whether a monarch, council, merchant group or several local authorities organised it.

ANSWER LINE: **Town planning means more than a grid seen from above.**

42

Deep Teaching Unit 4: The Economy as a Linked System — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Food production sustained towns; cotton and other fibres supported textile work; crafts transformed local and imported raw materials; weights and seals made transactions more regular; exchange linked villages, towns, coast and foreign ports.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Standard weights prove exchange and shared norms; they do not by themselves prove taxation by a named central monarch.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Each element makes more sense when connected to the next.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not learn crops, beads, weights and trade as disconnected lists.

ANSWER LINE: **Do not learn crops, beads, weights and trade as disconnected lists.**

43

Deep Teaching Unit 5: Evidence Ladder for Script, Polity, Society and Religion — [CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Archaeology does not mean “we know nothing”; it means that the strength of a claim changes with the evidence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Because the script is undeciphered, they cannot securely name a king, identify a god, translate a law or establish caste.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Standardisation therefore permits several models--central state, city-states or corporate elites.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Archaeology does not mean “we know nothing”; it means that the strength of a claim changes with the evidence.

ANSWER LINE: **Archaeology does not mean “we know nothing”; it means that the strength of a claim changes with the evidence.**

44

Deep Teaching Unit 6: De-urbanisation as Causal Sequence and Continuity — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

It is not a licence to choose one dramatic event.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

River shifts, local water stress, ecological change, changing external exchange and internal reorganisation are possible contributors whose weight differs by region and site.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

River shifts, local water stress, ecological change, changing external exchange and internal reorganisation are possible contributors whose weight differs by region and site.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It is not a licence to choose one dramatic event.

ANSWER LINE: **“Decline” asks why a particular city-centred system lost some urban features.**

45

Deep Teaching Unit 7: Site Memory Method and the Five-Sentence Answer — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Memory improves when a site is stored as a triad rather than as an isolated name.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Eliminate by geography and feature: a Rajasthan farming association points toward Kalibangan, a Kutch water/signboard pair toward Dholavira, and a Sindh water monument toward Mohenjo-daro.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Exam link: five-sentence answer. (1) Define the issue. (2) Make one claim. (3) attach a named site/material example. (4) add the evidence limit or regional contrast. (5) give a balanced verdict.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Memory improves when a site is stored as a triad rather than as an isolated name.

ANSWER LINE: **Memory improves when a site is stored as a triad rather than as an isolated name.**